convalescent home for Hezbollah fighters who were wounded or simply tired after months of fighting in southern Lebanon and were sent to the town to rest, with the help of Iranian elements. The area became an unusual point of intersection between Arab terrorist organizations and South American organized crime groups and drug cartels. The only difference between these two types of organizations was that the terrorist organizations fought for political or religious goals, while the criminal organizations fought for money and power for its own sake. But their doctrines and methods of action were almost identical, and their growing cooperation was based on the comparative advantages each party brought to the table.

There was a massive Iranian presence on the South American continent, established through Iran's diplomatic missions.

In hindsight, it can be said with certainty that in Argentina Hezbollah created the ideal conditions to plan and carry out attacks of the kind they did. The terrorists for such operations could enter the country under the cover of tourism and could easily hide among the large Arab communities throughout the country. Passports, if necessary, could be obtained from the Iranian embassy. Documentation of any other kind could be obtained for a fee, without registration and with no questions asked, in Foz do Iguacu. Weapons, explosives, and caches could be obtained in the Paraguayan city of Ciudad del Este, which was controlled for all intents and purposes by the cartels.

When Buenos Aires was the target, it was preferable for the operatives to prepare for and embark on the attack from a different point. In the case of the embassy attack, the starting point was most probably Ciudad del Este. Cars could be bought there without any trace of purchase, with the help of local collaborators. Operational apartments could be easily obtained, without registration or tracks. One could assume that the Iranian embassy used its capabilities to bring into the country anything that was difficult or unwise to bring in through the ordinary border crossings. The Iranian embassy could also provide other forms of assistance. Couriers and "cutoff" (personnel who disrupt the conveying of messages and/or materials) were copious and could blend in easily without being identified. Retreats were also very easy to plan in such an arena.

On one of my first visits to Langley, the director of the CIA hosted me for lunch in his private dining room with his deputies and other senior CIA officials. Over the meal, during a general conversation about terrorism, I